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AFP

164 DEAD AS TWIN EARTHQUAKES DEVASTATE VENEZUELA

■ Rescue workers carry a person on a stretcher out of a collapsed building following twin earthquakes in Caracas, Venezuela, yesterday. Two massive earthquakes, of magnitude 7.2 and 7.5, struck areas west of the capital Caracas yesterday evening, killing at least 164 people and injuring nearly 1,000, according to interim leader Delcy Rodríguez. The toll does not include data from La Guaira — designated a ‘disaster area’.

SEE ALSO P11

Gargash warns against reshaping the Gulf through aggression

Rubio says there is zero Gulf support for Hormuz transit charges

DUBAI
Gulf News Report

Dr Anwar Gargash, Diplomatic Adviser to the UAE President, warned yesterday against attempts to impose new geopolitical reality on GCC countries through a treacherous aggression, saying such actions would undermine, rather than promote, long-term regional stability.

In a post on X, Gargash said: “Such a treacherous aggression could not be used to reshape the strategic landscape of the Gulf region” arguing that imposing a fait accompli born of aggression would

not pave the way for stability, but rather sows new seeds of discord and conflict in the future. “New geopolitical realities cannot be imposed on the Gulf Arab countries as a result of treacherous aggression,” Gargash wrote.

Strategic importance

Gargash said this is specifically applied to the Strait of Hormuz, underscoring the strategic importance of the waterway to Gulf security and regional stability.

In another post earlier, Gargash said the visit of US Secretary of State Marco Rubio underscored the depth of the strategic partnership between the UAE and the US, describing ties between the two countries as steadily evolving amid regional and international developments.

Gargash said he was hon-

oured to attend Wednesday’s meeting between President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan and Rubio. Gargash said the UAE’s wisdom and leadership, alongside the courage of its citizens and the strength of its institutions, had earned clear recognition and appreciation during what he described as an exceptional period.

After meeting Gulf officials in Bahrain, Rubio said GCC leaders wanted to be informed and involved in any future decisions affecting the region. Rubio also said there was “zero support” among Gulf states for imposing charges on ships using Gulf waters.

He added that the aim was to restore the Strait of Hormuz to its pre-conflict status, stressing that it remains an international waterway.

SEE ALSO P6, 10

India to raise passport fees by up to 75% from July 1

UAE flyers to India must now fill a new health form

DUBAI
BY SAJILA SASEENDRAN
Chief Reporter

India is raising passport fees by up to 75 per cent starting July 1, according to a gazette notification issued by the country’s Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on June 20 under the Passports (Amendment) Rules.

When Gulf News contacted the Indian Embassy in Abu Dhabi, officials confirmed that the fee hike would be applicable to passport applicants in the UAE and across the world. However, the Indian missions in the UAE are yet to announce the new fee structure for applicants here. Gulf News was told that the

updated rates would be announced within days.

Health declaration

Also, for travellers flying from the UAE to India, there is a new step you need to add to your pre-departure checklist: filling out a mandatory online health declaration form before you board. India has relaunched its Air Suvidha portal — now upgraded to version 2.0 — requiring all international passengers arriving in the country to submit a digital health form ahead of their flight.

The move comes in direct response to the World Health Organisation’s declaration of the Ebola/Bundibugyo virus disease outbreak as a Public Health Emergency of International Concern. The form — called a Self-Declaration Form (SDF) — can be completed up to 24 hours before your arrival in India.

UAE expands visa-on-arrival for 6 nationalities

ELIGIBLE TRAVELLERS CAN NOW OBTAIN 14-DAY OR 60-DAY PERMITS

DUBAI
BY KHITAM AL AMIR
Chief News Editor

The UAE expanded its visa-on-arrival programme to include nationals of six countries and their accompanying family members.

Under the new decision, nationals of Indonesia, Vietnam, Thailand, the Philippines, Kenya, and South Africa holding ordinary passports, along with their accompanying family members, are eligible to obtain a 14-day or 60-day visa on arrival, provided they hold a valid residence permit issued by the United States, a European Union member state, the United Kingdom, Singapore, Japan, Republic of Korea, Australia, New Zealand, or Canada.

The initiative reflects the UAE’s flexible entry and residency framework and its commitment to facilitating travel while providing visitors with a seamless travel experience.

Fostering closer ties

In this regard, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs affirmed that expanding eligibility for the visa-on-arrival programme reflects the UAE’s commitment to strengthening bilateral relations with friendly countries and fostering closer economic, cultural and people-to-people ties.

The initiative also creates greater opportunities for na-

The 14-day visa may be extended once while the holder is in the UAE, whereas the 60-day visa is issued for a single stay and is not extendable.

tionals of these countries to experience the UAE’s unique cultural landscape, world-class tourism offerings, dynamic economy, attractive business environment, and globally recognised infrastructure.

The Ministry further emphasised that it will continue to work in close coordination with the relevant national authorities to facilitate the movement of travellers, streamline consular procedures, and reinforce the UAE’s position as a leading global destination for business, investment, entrepreneurship, and exceptional talent.

The Authority noted that the 14-day visa may be extended once while the holder is in the UAE, whereas the 60-day visa is issued for a single stay and is not extendable.

Upon the expiry of either visa, holders are required to depart the country. An overstay fine of Dh50 per day will apply to those who remain beyond the permitted period.

The total issuance fee for the 14-day visa is Dh100, while the total issuance fee for the 60-day visa is Dh250.

FRIDAY

Our summer edition promises a fair amount of sizzle!



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